

THE NIGHT IT BEGINS

The Star That Remembers

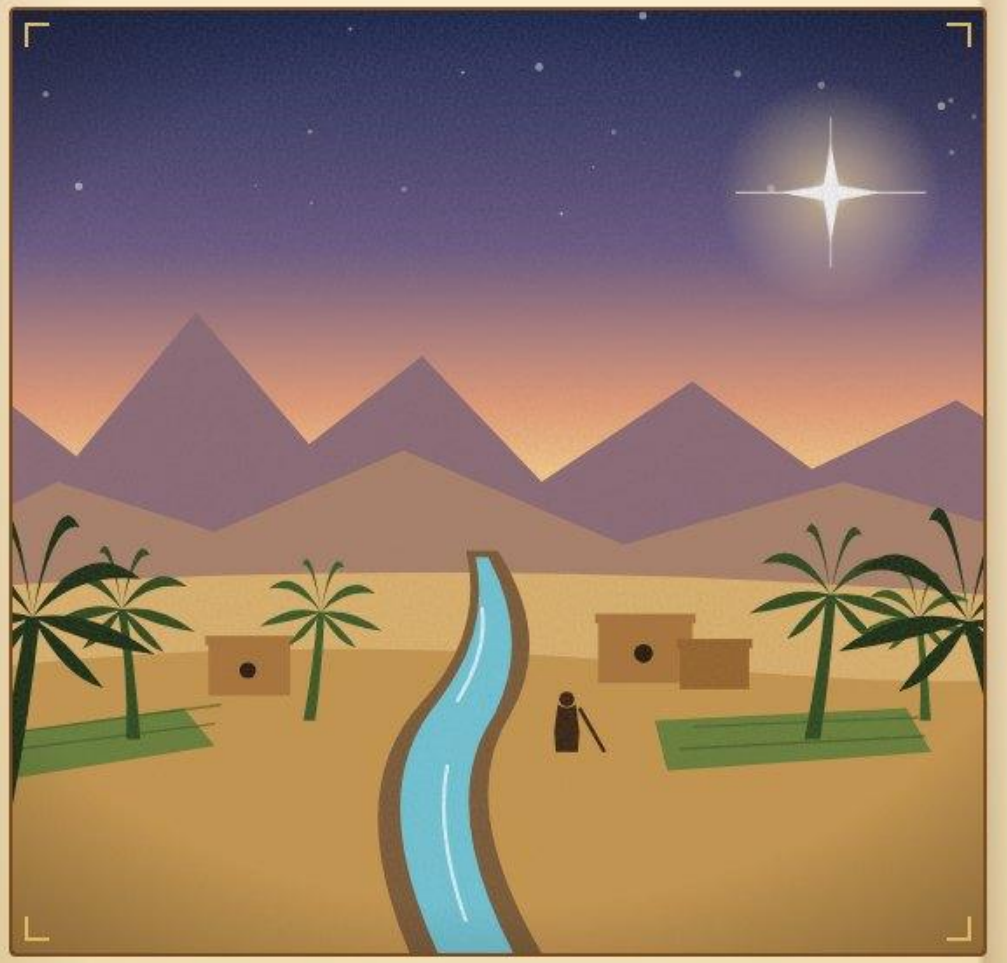
النجم الذي لا ينسى

The desert forgets everything. Footprints, campfires, whole caravans: gone by morning. But one star remembers. Its name is Suhail, and when it rises at summer's end the heat breaks and the night turns kind. Tonight you stand on a dune as it clears the horizon, brighter than you have ever seen it. An old storyteller waits beside you. "That star has watched this land longer than anyone can count," he says. "Walk with me. It will show you what it saw."

الصحراء تنسى كل شيء، إلا نجماً واحداً. الليلة يطلع سهيل، وإلى جانبك راوٍ عجوز يقول: «سِر معي، وسأُريك ما رأى».

I am Rawi, keeper of stories. You will be the keeper of a town. First, come and see what was built before you.

▸ Draft text · sources



THREE THOUSAND YEARS AGO

Water Under the Sand

ماء تحت الرمل

The star tilts, and the dunes fold away like a turned page. You stand among dry hills, and beneath your feet the earth is whispering. Kneel. Put your ear to the ground. Water, running in the dark. The people here have cut a tunnel through the earth, a falaj, sloped so gently that the water walks to their gardens by itself. Where it surfaces, palms stand green against the stone. Centuries on, at Mleiha to the north, traders will stamp their own coins in bright silver. The desert was never empty. It was waiting for clever hands.

تميل النجمة فتنطوي الكثبان كصفحة تُقلب. تحت قدميك ماء يجري في العتمة: فلج شقّه الناس ليمشي الماء وحده إلى بساتينهم. لم تكن الصحراء خالية قط.

In your town, water comes first too. Every building drinks, so choose well where you dig.

▸ Draft text · sources



AROUND THE YEAR 630

One Tongue Under the Lamps

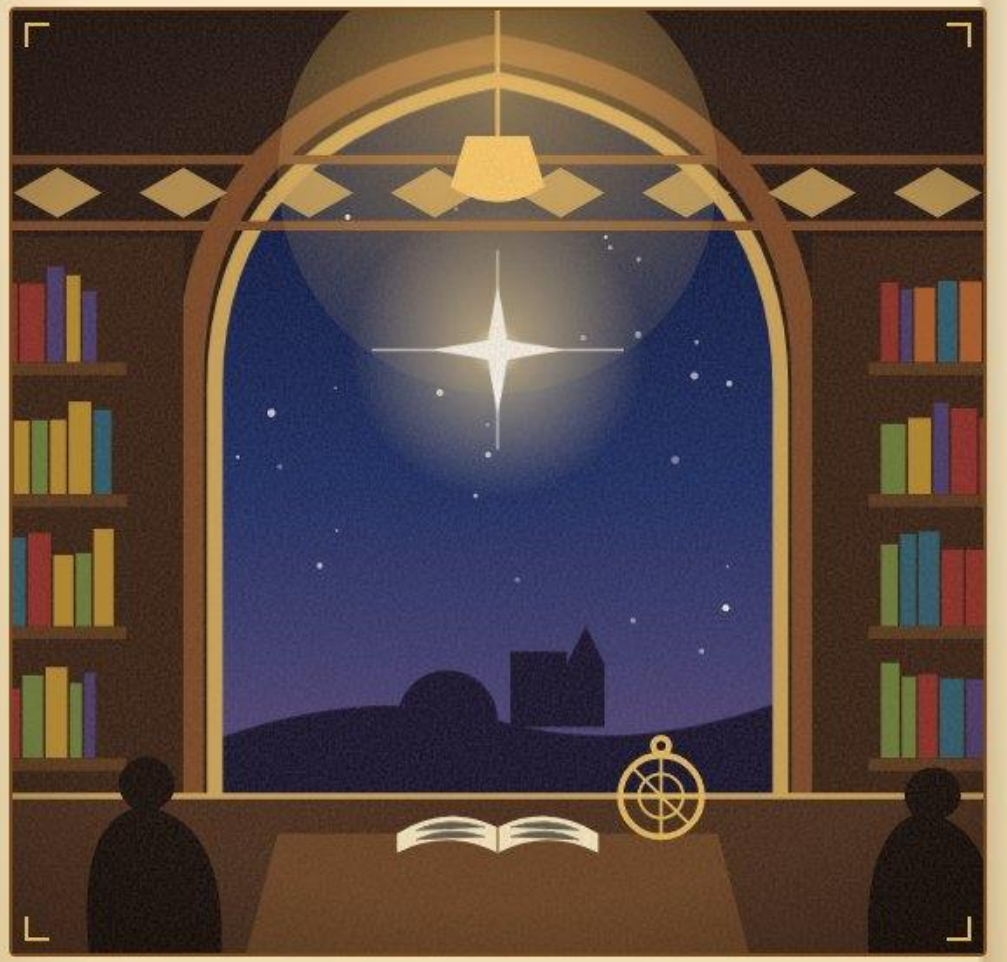
لسان واحد تحت القناديل

The star leads you on, to a town at dusk. Lamps wake one by one in the arches of its mosque, and the lanes run toward it like streams toward a river. Something new is in the air. A merchant from a distant city seals a bargain here, and his word will still hold when he is home, because the law is now the same in both places. The language is the same too. Arabic has become a thread, and it is stitching a thousand towns into one cloth. By the road, a well endowed for strangers waits for whoever comes thirsty.

مدينة عند الغروب، وقناديل تُضاء في أروقة مسجدها. صار العهد يُحفظ من مدينة إلى أخرى، وصارت العربية خيطاً يجمع ألف بلدة في نسيج واحد.

I tell this age through what it built: the mosque, the court, the endowed well. Out of respect, no prophet, companion or caliph appears in my telling.

▸ Draft text · sources



BAGHDAD, TWELVE CENTURIES AGO

The House Where Ink Never Dries

بيت لا يجفّ فيه الحبر

A carved door swings open, and behind it are more books than you knew the world could hold. This is Baghdad, and the lamps here burn until dawn. Scholars lean over pages from Greece, Persia and India, turning them into Arabic, arguing, testing, adding discoveries of their own. One of them, al-Khwarizmi, is writing a book on how to find the unknown. Its title will give the world the word algebra. His name will become the word algorithm. The device in your hand still carries it. It all began with ink, a lamp, and someone willing to pay for both.

في بغداد قناديل لا تنطفئ، وعلماء ينقلون علوم الأمم إلى العربية ويزيدون عليها. هنا يكتب الخوارزمي كتاباً سيهب العالم كلمتَي الجبر والخوارزمية.

What your town learns, it never forgets. Spend on knowledge early and every later age grows faster.

▸ Draft text · sources



THE OPEN SEA, FIVE CENTURIES AGO

The Wind That Keeps Its Promise

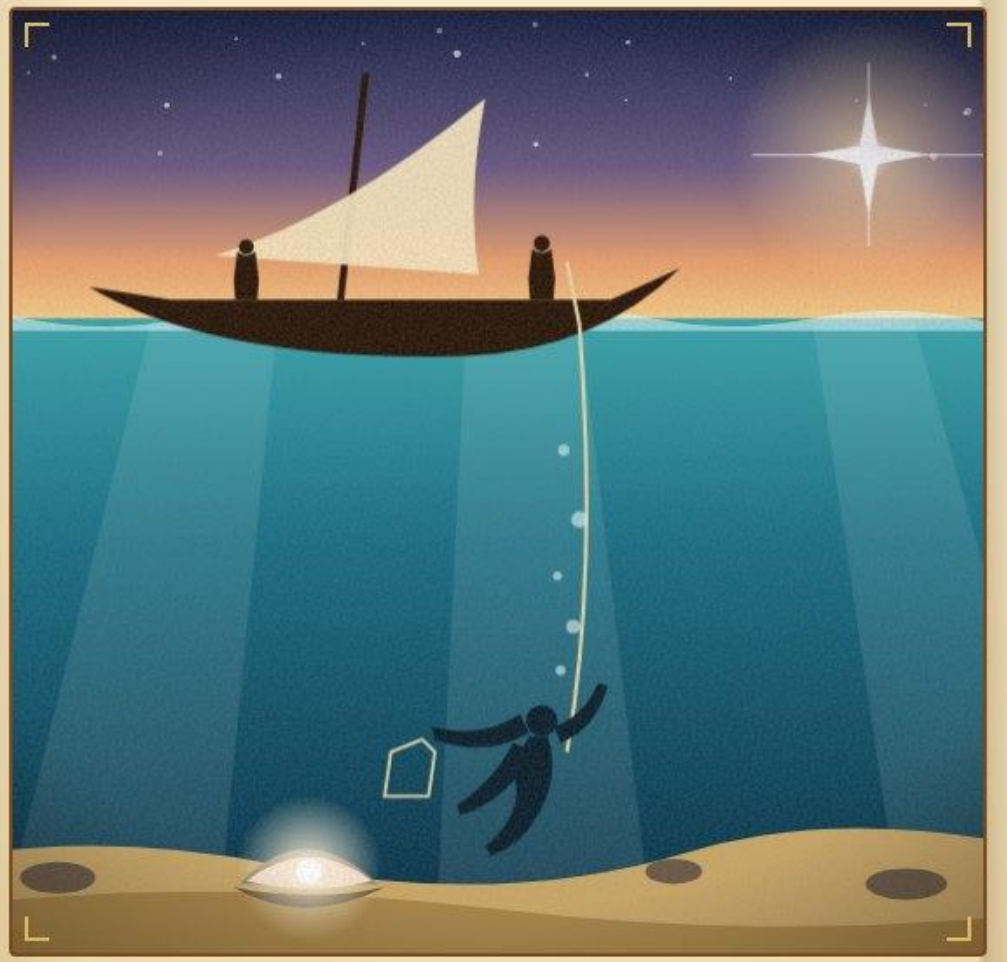
ريح تفي بوعدها

Salt on your lips. The deck tilts, the great sail fills, and the shore slips under the horizon. Out here the wind is a promise. It carries you east in one season and brings you home in the next, and the captain who misses it waits months on a foreign shore. The crew speak of a navigator from Julfar, Ahmad ibn Majid, who wrote the whole ocean down, its stars, its winds, its harbours, so that no pilot after him need sail blind. They call him the Lion of the Sea. High above the mast, Suhail keeps pace with the ship.

الريح هنا وعد: تحملك شرقاً في موسم وتعيدك في موسم. ويتحدث البحّارة عن ابن ماجد، أسد البحار، الذي دوّن البحر كله كي لا يُبحر ربّان بعده أعمى.

Your ships will sail by the seasons too. Choose the day as carefully as you choose the route.

▸ Draft text · sources



THE GULF, IN THE SUMMERS OF THE GREAT DIVE

The Song Above the Deep

أغنية فوق الأعماق

Now the water lies warm and green, and the boat is still. A diver fills his chest, grips the rope, and drops into the dark with a clip on his nose and a stone to pull him down. Above him a hauler waits, rope in both hands. On deck the nahham sings, and the whole crew pulls to his song. When the diver breaks the surface there is an oyster in his basket and, once in a long while, a small cold moon inside it. The work is cruel and the debts are long. But when Suhail rises, the season ends, and every sail turns for home.

يغوص الغوّاص في العتمة والنهّام يغنّي فوقه. وفي المحارة أحياناً قمر صغير بارد. فإذا طلع سهيل انتهى الموسم وعادت الأشرعة إلى الديار.

This is the age where your own town begins. The boats are waiting for you.

▸ Draft text · sources



THE SAME SHORE, 1930 TO 1962

The Quiet Years, and the Fire

سنوات الصمت، ثم النار

Then one summer the buyers do not come. Far away the world has grown poor, and pearls raised on farms in Japan are selling cheap. The boats are hauled up the beach and left to the sun. You walk among their ribs for what feels like thirty years. The people stay. They fish, tend their palms, and wait. Then, out over an old pearl bank near Das Island, a tower of steel finds something sleeping under the seabed. In July 1962 the first tanker sails from Abu Dhabi. The sea had kept one more gift, deeper than any diver could reach.

ذات صيف لم يأتِ التجّار. وتُركت السفن للشمس. ثم وجد برج من فولاذ شيئاً نائماً تحت قاع البحر. كان البحر يخبّئ هدية أخرى، أعمق من أن يبلغها غوّاص.

In the game this is your hardest night. What you built before it decides how you come through.

▸ Draft text · sources



2 DECEMBER 1971

Seven Hands, One Flag

سبع أيادٍ وعلم واحد

The star brings you to a morning. A crowd stands around a bare flagpole, waiting. For three years the rulers of this coast have talked, disagreed, and talked again, because the old protector is leaving and every small state must choose: stand alone, or stand together. Today six of them raise one flag, red, green, white and black. Before the winter is out, a seventh joins. You watch the cloth open in the wind and understand what you have been walking toward. The wells, the books, the sails, the pearls: it was one story all along. Now it has a name.

في الثاني من ديسمبر ١٩٧١ رفعت ستّ إمارات علماً واحداً، ولحقت بها السابعة قبل أن ينقضي الشتاء. كانت الآبار والكتب والأشرعة واللآلئ حكاية واحدة. وها قد صار لها اسم.

Everything you build is tested here. How your town's story ends is your choice.

▸ Draft text · sources



TONIGHT

The Shore That Waits

الشاطئ الذي ينتظر

The road of light ends where it began: an empty shore, one well, a few palms, and Suhail hanging low over the water. Rawi lowers himself onto the sand. “I have shown you what others built,” he says. “Diggers and judges, scholars and pilots, divers and founders. Not one of them knew how the story would end. They built anyway.” He looks at the bare ground, then at you. “This page is empty. I think the star has been saving it for you.”

ينتهي درب النور حيث بدأ: شاطئ خالٍ وبئر واحدة وسهيل فوق الماء. يقول الراوي: «هذه الصفحة فارغة. أظن أن النجم كان يحفظها لك».

Build, gather, trade, and answer my questions when I ask. I will be beside you.

▸ Draft text · sources

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